

Vietnam Divided

By 1955, Vietnam had won its independence, but was divided. In South Vietnam, the Catholic nationalist Ngo Dinh Diem emerged as ruler with the backing of the United States, while in North Vietnam, Ho Chi Minh's regime imposed a communist system.

◀◀ BEFORE

In 1954, France, facing defeat by Viet Minh guerrillas in the First Indochina War, signed the Geneva Accords.

PEACE TERMS

The French officially declared Vietnam independent under former emperor Bo Dai. The **Geneva Accords** partitioned the country at the 17th parallel, leaving two Vietnamese governments in place—Ho Chi Minh's Democratic Republic of Vietnam in Hanoi and Bo Dai's State of Vietnam in Saigon. Democratic elections to reunite the country were timetabled for 1956.

For 300 days after the signing of the Geneva Accords, the border between North and South Vietnam remained open. Around a million Vietnamese moved from North Vietnam to the South, primarily Catholics who feared the consequences of communist rule. Such qualms were encouraged by propaganda promulgated by the CIA, and justified by the hardline attitude of the communist authorities. About 90,000 people moved in the opposite direction, to the North—chiefly Viet Minh guerrillas who had fought against the French. However, many Viet Minh activists covertly remained in the South after partition.

American support

The United States, committed to opposing the spread of communist influence worldwide, began to assert its presence in the South well before the French completed their withdrawal. Although the Americans did not consider their chances of saving South Vietnam from communism to be high, they took on the task of advising the South Vietnamese government and army. To their surprise, they found that the main politician they were backing, Ngo Dinh Diem, was capable of asserting his authority effectively.

As prime minister under President Bao Dai, Diem had crushed the Binh Xuyen, a mafia-like organization with the status of an independent army, and cracked down on the militias of the Cao Dai and Hoa Hao religious sects. These militias played an important role in politics and had long defied government control, although some members joined remnants of the Viet Minh.